



The Gaming Room

My friend's older
brother took my
girlfriend

JJ VALE

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PMI

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Chase wrapped his big arms around Noelle from behind and pulled her back against him so hard she stumbled before landing against his chest.

“I swear to god, this girl is going make me do something I think we’ll both regret,” he said, and everybody roared with laughter.

As did I, though halfheartedly. Noelle looked at me with bulging eyes but also a shocked grin. The messages were mixed from the start that whole night, her eyes pleading with me, Aren’t you going to do anything? her mouth, I’ve never been so excited.

That was Noelle all over. Even when we decided I was her boyfriend and she was my girlfriend, we both stumbled around the words unsure and ambiguous.

“So like exclusive, right?” I said.

She was shocked I’d even have to clarify. “Of course, oh my god!” The mere suggestion of anything or anyone else made her hide her blushing face in my neck. “End of discussion!” she murmured in my hair and she pulled her face up only enough to kiss me hot and deep.

I didn’t say anything to her about just how hard and deep she kissed me then, she was already blushing to the point of heart palpitations with any talk of arousal or things to do with bed that weren’t sleeping.

I wasn’t much better, which was why we were probably made for each other. By mutual yet unspoken agreement, one or the other of us fast-forwarded over scenes of making out and anything over that in any show we were watching.

I’m not saying we didn’t do anything. But if we did, it was strictly in bed, lights out, unspoken, mostly under at least a sheet. If there were sounds at all, they were momentary escapes, muffled with hands or shut lips or pillows.

Which was why seeing her allow herself to be pulled back into Chase’s chest like that fascinated me first of all, more than any other feeling it might

or might not have given me. By the end of the night, I had more feelings in deeper conflicting with each other than I was able to cope with.

Chase was my good friend Rhett's older brother, maybe 28 or so to our 22, like Noelle too. He was charismatic, confident, and successful right out of college with some start-up he created with roommates. It was a classic story. They had notorious parties at his big house, and Rhett said I were allowed to come to one, even to bring Noelle.

Big house parties were not really our thing, but this house was incredible. Chase was apparently a great guy, and the people there were those kinds you read about in the news. Of course we were going to go.

"You got to dress up, I think," I told Noelle. She pulled her fingers through her hair and stared in the mirror at herself. "You mean I can't go in my usual sweats and hoody?"

I kissed her forehead. "Maybe I want to show you off."

"Ahh!" she cried and she buried her face in my neck again. "You would really want to do that?"

It was a joke and I didn't expect her to take it seriously. But now it would be even more embarrassing for her if I told her I was only kidding about showing her off. She was already 50-50 on bailing, and between her and I, we bailed on 80% of our calendars.

"No seriously, Noelle, I love showing you off. Get dressed up really nice, okay?"

She pulled her face back and studied my eyes one at a time. "You mean that?"

"Of course I mean it!"

She narrowed her eyes at me and pursed her grin as though doubts raced through her mind. "You like showing me off?"

"Sure, maybe it's a thing."

"What kind of thing?"

"Just get dressed up, when do you get a chance to?"

"Okay then, but no peeking until I say."

"Okay," I said, unsure what I was agreeing to anymore.

I was banished from the bed and bathroom for over an hour. She didn't call me when she was ready, she just silently re-emerged into the living room where I was on the couch with my controller flying around the Monaco F1 course.

I drove straight into the wall. “Holy shit,” I said to myself when I noticed her. Noelle covered her face in her hands.

“Too much?” she squeezed out.

I couldn’t take my eyes off her. She was in peep-toe platform pumps, a shimmering tight short blue dress, and she was wearing eye shadow and liner and lashes with glowing glossy lips. “Where did you get that from?” I said in a weakened voice.

She shrugged and stepped toward me with as much bravery as she could muster. “It was from that wedding last year,” she said. “They made us wear these. I kept mine. Do you like it?”

“Holy fuck,” was all I could say. She did not look like my meek and quiet book-reading and tea sipping girlfriend Noelle anymore.

She nudged her legs between my knees and blocked out my view of the screen on the wall opposite the couch, her fingers twisting together, her hands down in front of her body, her shoulders scrunched up to her ears. “Still want to show me off?” she said in a tiny voice barely audible.

I couldn’t talk, I only chuckled. She reached down and used her finger on my chin to close my mouth.

Now she was being pawed by the man whose house we were invited to, held back against his body, and she reached up to hang her hands from his forearms where they crossed over her upper chest.

“Who did you say you’re here with?” he said to her, though it wasn’t in private, the kitchen being packed with people all talking loud and laughing.

“My boyfriend?” she said, twisting her face over her shoulder and up to his face.

The man leaned his face down to her and pressed his lips to her lips. I watched it but could not believe it. But what came next was even more dreamlike. My careful, conservative girlfriend pushed her face up to meet his, twisted further around, gripped his arm harder, and returned the kiss.

People watched and laughed. I snickered too. I was across the kitchen watching the whole thing.

“This your sweetie?” he said.

I nodded at Chase and I felt my face blush. I’d never been around people like him, so rich and powerful, so confident, nor included by them the way he was talking to me.

“She really got herself done up for my party, didn’t she,” he said. We weren’t very close in the kitchen, so while it felt like a private conversation, it was through a lot of other people. But most of them seemed to not notice or listen or if they were listening, they just casually watched it.

“She spent two hours getting ready,” I said, nodding. She was blushing badly.

“You spent two hours getting ready for me?” he said, leaning his head down over her shoulder where he pushed his face in her hair and kissed her neck.

Noelle blushed even harder and tilted her head at me with a look of “Why would you tell him that?!”

I shrugged. Too many things were happening all at once.

“I got ready for your party, not for you specifically,” she said up to him, and she grinned with her own new-found and playful defiance.

He knew what it was. He dragged his hands down her sides and used his fingertips to tickle her around her hips.

“I’m not ticklish if that’s what you think you’re trying to do,” she said.

They were holding eye contact the whole time. I drank my beer, very good high-end beer it was, and looked around the kitchen to see if anyone else was taking note of what was going on up at the other end. But nobody seemed to be aware.

He snorted lightly and pushed his fingers down further to the high hem of her tight dress and curled them around against her skin there.

“You better not,” she said. But she wasn’t trying to pull away from him. If anything it looked to me from across the room she was leaning back into him even more than before.

I chuckled to myself and looked down in my beer glass. I was amazed how well she was handling herself. I was impressed. Noelle would normally be running to me and hiding under my arm if anyone so much as spoke to her at parties like this, full of strangers. I guess she was feeling comfortable around this guy. I could tell why, though. He had that sort of way about him.

Noelle looked at me and gently pushed Chase’s hands from her legs. “Hey, you two want a tour of the house? Has anybody showed you around yet?” He lifted his face to me.

Noelle continued staring at me too, and not answering him. I had a hard time reading her expression. She was grinning crookedly, her face slightly

down but her eyes up through their tops not coming off my eyes. Was I supposed to say yes to him? Was I supposed to say no? Did she want me to come rescue her? Or did she want me to leave her alone to go with him on this tour?

“You want the tour,” one of Chase’s older friends leaned over and said to me. “Believe me. House is fucking out of this world.”

“Okay,” I said over to Chase.

He pulled a grin up the whole side of his face. “Well come on, then,” he said, and I watched his hand close around Noelle’s hand. He lead her through the crowd in the kitchen, her wobbling on her way-too-high platform pumps trying to keep up the way he pulled her.

“Are you coming too?” she said over her shoulder at me as she was pulled past me, which struck me as an odd question, because of course I would be coming too. Her eyes, though, it wasn’t just the usual level of make up, they were alive, they were sparkling. She was obviously feeling something. So was I, to be honest, getting this kind of attention from a great guy like Chase, talking directly with us. But with Noelle, her eyes, her grin, it was something more.

He took us down the hallway away from the kitchen. He threw his arm around my shoulder and pulled me up alongside him. His other arm was around Noelle’s waist. “You don’t mind me grabbing your girlfriend like this, right? She’s just so hot, I can’t help myself,” he said and he laughed.

I looked across him at Noelle.

“I should think he minds very much,” she said and she chuckled, not taking her eyes off me.

Not for the first time, nor the last, that night did Noelle throw me for a loop. She was playing some game with me, she was trying on some new persona, she was pretending to be someone she was not. She could get like that in small doses. She chalked it up to heroines in her novels she was always reading.

But this was in public, or at least with someone else, and not just with me in private when she was playacting as someone else. I couldn’t tell how far she was going to take it. For example, she gave a slight British touch to her voice when she said “I should think...”

“I’m fine,” I said to him looking at her.

She just snorted a breath out her nose and narrowed her eyes doubtfully at me with a private grin. But she also placed her hand flat on his stomach

as she looked away.

“You like reading, I can tell, you look like a reader,” he said to her and he leaned down to kiss the top of her head. By now his little kisses like that came and went without notice or reaction from either of us.

It’s funny how quickly things can become normal.

“Can confirm,” she said. “Big time reader.”

“She does nothing but read,” I said to Chase and he and I shared a private knowing roll of the eyes.

Chase stopped us in front of excessively tall double wood doors for dramatic effect before he thrust them both open. I swear Noelle nearly wobbled off her shoes and fell to her knees. Before us was a classical library as though transported from some old small building in Oxford. And at the far end of the amazing room was a wall that was entirely a bank of small lead-lined windows overlooking a wildly entangled garden with a fountain and benches.

“Oh my god,” Noelle murmured and she dropped Chase’s hand and was instantly absorbed into the room. She touched book bindings on the tall shelves, ran her fingertips over the green leather-topped reading table, turned around and around with her head thrown back and her hair falling loose down to her waist. “I can’t believe it!” she cried.

I went in too, marveling at the books as much as at the room. “This is all yours?” I said, instantly realizing how dumb it was to say that.

He ran his hand around the back of Noelle’s neck where she had pulled a book out to open in her hands. “I don’t know, is this all yours?” he said, and Noelle blushed hard and spun around to look back at him.

“He likes to think so,” she said and she grinned at me.

“Any man would, a girl like you,” he said, and he gathered her in his arms from behind again.

Noelle continued to make herself appear to be still absorbed by the hefty hardcover tome open in her hands, even while he pulled her hair from her neck, touched her under her ear, leaned down and kissed her exposed neck.

“What do you say, though, Noelle?”

She shuddered from his kisses further down her neck. “I belong to no man,” she said, quoting some writer no doubt, and she laughed at herself.

“You’re pretty quiet over there, Reid,” he said. “No opinion on the matter?”

“Maybe he likes it,” Noelle said privately to Chase but making sure it was loud enough for me to hear.

It made me blush and nod at her as though to say, “Well played...”

“No shame in that, lots of guys do,” Chase said.

Noelle guffawed and rolled her eyes. “As if.”

“You’d be surprised. Haven’t you read any books with that sort of male character?” He eased the book out of her hands and closed it on the table. “Consider this book officially borrowed,” he said, and he turned her against him so they were now facing each other at body-touching range.

“No,” she said but her voice was shaky.

“You neither Reid?” he said, but he wasn’t looking at me. He was lifting the tiny shoulder strap of Noelle’s dress and kissing her along her shoulder.

I looked up at the ceiling, I looked far out the windows, I looked at the table and the floor. I looked everywhere but at Noelle or Chase’s hands that brushed up and down her sides and down over her hips. I couldn’t believe she was simply letting him to that to her.

Her turned her again to face me and he pulled her backward with him until he sat on the edge of the table. His knees opened up and she nestled between them.

“It’s okay, Reid,” he said, “it’s natural, it’s normal.”

I laughed and rolled my eyes. “It’s just, we haven’t seen a place like this before.”

“I know,” he said softly. His fingers stretched down the sides of Noelle’s hips until they reached the bare skin of her thighs. Then he started to walk his fingers in place so her dress crept up her thighs slowly by centimeters. She closed her eyes.

“It can be overwhelming a little bit, right?” he said.

I nodded and grinned but watched Noelle’s legs become more exposed to the dim amber light from the library lamps.

“Do you want me to stop?” he said quietly to Noelle.

With her eyes opening and dead set on mine, she paused a moment, but then she shook her head No.

He smiled at me. “She likes it, you can tell, can’t you.”

I licked my lips and dropped my mouth partly open, my breath was coming so hard and fast. “I guess so, yeah. Noelle,” I said.

She took a moment but she opened her eyes again. “Do you like it?”

She pursed her lips and her eyebrows curved sympathetically. And then she nodded Yes.

What was it that was going on? What brought about this sudden and total out of character turn in her? I was fascinated more than anything. Was it the way he had such total control?

He had worked the bottom of her dress up by small increments until it was bunched around her hips and her white lace panties were now drawn into my view and I swallowed hard. She either didn't notice or didn't care, neither of which possibilities were anything like Noelle up until a minute ago.

He kissed her head and she instantly twisted around and up to him and sank her tongue in his mouth, reaching behind her to cup her hand around the back of his neck. He ran his fingertips as lightly as a breeze over the textured front of her panties and her knees pressed together, her ankles wobbled in her high pumps, and she stomped one foot down and inhaled sharply.

If she was up to some elaborate playacting joke, she sure had me. It looked real enough.

Chase then chuckled and straightened the bottom of her dress for her and took her hand in his. "Come on, there's much more house to see."

Noelle seemed to regain herself and snapped out of a near trance. She exhaled through her puffed cheeks. But Chase wasn't allowing much recovery time.

I followed them out the door back into the broad high hallway and back into the light streaming down from the glass dome high above. Now Noelle hung on his arm, hugged it to her body, and whenever Chase paused, she turned to him, kissed him deeply on the mouth, made out with him, necked with him. She did it at every chance. Chase just looked askance at me and said nothing. Noelle was pressing herself against him all the way.

"Did you build this or did you buy it like this?" she said, marveling at the double grand staircase that circled around up into the next floor under the massive glass dome above.

"This was actually built over a hundred years ago, but I had it updated, of course."

"Of course," she said, and she pressed herself into him harder standing on the stair one above the one he was on to be level with him. "You coming upstairs to see?" she said to me, again asking a question to which the

answer should have been obvious. What was she really saying to me? When did Noelle ever want to be not with me?

He shuffled with his general air of fitness up the steps and Noelle laughed and tripped and he caught her and swung her up in his arms to carry her fireman style to the top.

He waited for me to catch up but didn't put Noelle down. Instead she threw her arms around his neck and hung from him as though it was the most comfortable thing in the world.

"Lots of rooms for overnight guests," he said, pushing one open with his foot. Noelle reached to push it further open before settling back against his chest, sitting in his arms. She found me over his shoulder. "We should stay over some night," she said.

"You'd be welcome to anytime," he said and he carried her down the hall toward massive double doors. She grinned at me over his shoulder, before biting his neck, sucking on his ear, and looking at me with sly eyes.

"So you live alone here?" she said as he reached for the knob.

"All by my lonesome," he said with a flourish.

"I highly doubt that," she said and she sank her mouth on his again. I could see her tongue enter him.

Of course it was wildly wrong, the whole thing that was going on. Of course I should have stopped it right there long ago. But like I said, normal has a way of creeping away from you until you're still holding its leash deep in the foreign jungle. I knew it was wrong, what she was doing, what she was allowing him to do to her, but exactly when and where do you say something? And to whom, him or her?

Chase flung open both double doors to the master suite and Noelle inhaled with wonder. He let her down and she floated through the huge room.

He turned to me, hands on his hips. "They all do this when you bring them up here," he said to me, and he chuckled.

"It is pretty impressive," I said, standing beside him with my hands on my hips too.

"Go look around, you'll love it," he said. "Noelle," he called to where she disappeared out of sight. "Don't forget to try the bed!"

She gasped back at him. "This bathroom is incredible!"

Chase slapped my back and headed toward the bathroom. "Check that out, he said.

I found the handle for the French doors out onto the balcony and stepped out and looked down into the same garden we saw out the library windows. It was ten times larger than I thought it was, a labyrinth.

I studied it leaning over the balcony when I heard a tiny brief high pitched cry from the bathroom across the bedroom behind me.

I stepped back inside unsure of what I heard. It could have been a bird, a squirrel. But then I heard it again definitely from the bathroom. I took a few steps toward the doorway but then felt awkward, like I was spying or shouldn't hear it. I went back to the door to the balcony unable to decide if I should go back out or stay inside, or even go out there and close the door behind me.

I could hear Noelle clearly now, there were no other sounds. "Uh-huh?" she said. "No," I heard. "Yeah," in a breathy voice. I definitely would have gone straight in there if it sounded like she was in trouble. I would have crossed the room in a flash if I thought she needed my help. But I heard her laugh lightly, I heard her gasp with rapid breath, and I heard her say "yeah" again with a kind of enthusiasm, if a shy kind.

I was caught staring and I nearly broke my nose I spun around so fast against the open balcony doors. It was Chase, leaning out of the bathroom. "Just going to..." he said, and he shut the bathroom door to close them both inside.

So I went back out onto the balcony and gazed around at the garden and the small private forest beyond and the pond out there too. This guy had everything, I thought. Imagine being him.

About ten or so minutes later, I heard a light rapping on the glass behind me. Chase was gesturing for me to come back inside. "You okay?" he said.

"Yeah."

He chuckled. "Okay, just checking. Your girl is just redoing her lips, I think," he said. "She'll be a moment. I'll be out in the hallway, go in, see if she's okay," he said and he gestured to the bathroom door that was partly open. He sauntered out of the bedroom and I bent as I walked to peer into the bathroom.

I came in and found Noelle leaning with her hips into the counter edge putting her face close to the mirror. She was carefully reapplying her lip gloss. "Just a sec," she said in a low steady voice. I looked around. It was like nothing else I'd ever seen. Maybe on websites I'd seen something like it, in homes of the rich or something.

She pressed her lips together and turned around. She closed the bathroom door and sat back on the edge of the counter. “He wants to take you downstairs to show you his gaming room,” she said. “He says it’s the most private room in the house.”

“That’s cool.”

“Reid, do you want to know what I just did with him in here?”

“I was on the balcony.”

She pressed her lips together again to spread her gloss and dropped the tube into her clutch.

“I just want you to know that whatever it was, I wanted to do it.”

“What did you do?” I said with a smirk.

“You really can’t figure it out?”

I hooked my thumb over my shoulder. “I was outside the whole time.” She was so different. The way she talked, how she looked. It was like she crossed through some portal.

“Didn’t you care what we were doing in the bathroom together with the door closed?”

“But I don’t know what you were doing.”

“You could probably guess. You watched him close the door. With me inside her with him.”

“I know,” I said in a small voice. I felt weak. “I don’t know.”

She reached out and held both my hands in hers, forming a bridge between us with our swinging arms. “He said that maybe you liked it, that it wasn’t just a matter of not minding it but actually liking it.”

I laughed. “Oh, I don’t know about that!”

“But you didn’t come back. Did you hear me? He wasn’t letting me keep quiet.”

I took a while to answer. “I heard a little, yeah.”

“And you still didn’t wonder?”

“Of course I wondered.”

“But you knew, didn’t you.”

“Not exactly.”

“Do you want me to tell you what I did to him?”

I looked at her fresh lip gloss.

“He said it might turn you on a little bit if I told you what I did.”

“That would be pretty fucked up, though,” I said.

“He said it’s not really that unusual, when it’s a higher status male. Do you think that’s right? Is he higher status than you, do you think?”

She looked at me now with wide searching eyes.

“Well look at this place, he has everything in the world, he’s super rich.”

“So does that mean that seeing him touch me, kiss me even, right in front of you, does that make you proud? Knowing what I did with him right in here?”

“Is that what he said?” I guffawed like nothing could be more ridiculous. “That I’d be turned on by it?”

She nodded. “Maybe you’d feel a little higher status yourself if the highest status male prefers your mate.”

I laughed now. “You’re hardly my mate!”

“You know what he means.”

“Okay well, I heard you, okay? It didn’t sound like you were fighting him off either.”

She crossed her arms over her chest and looked sideways. “I don’t know what might happen later. I mean if I’m not going to stop him and you’re not going to stop him either, what do you think is going to happen?”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“He says it’s only right if you’re there, he says he doesn’t want to hide it from you.”

“Do you want to hide it from me?”

“I don’t know what I want, to be honest. But I don’t know if I have a choice anymore anyway.”

“What is that supposed to mean?”

She pursed her lips. “It means, Reid, that this girl isn’t exactly in full control of her body’s reactions to him. You can feel it too, I can tell. He has this...”

“Magnetism, I think they call it.”

“He says it’s okay to do it, that it probably won’t affect our relationship at all because he’s so much higher status, he’s no threat.”

“Is that what he said?”

She grinned but used her hand to hide it. “Not in so many words. But he really wants to. I can tell.”

“We should get out of the bathroom anyway, I think he’s still waiting for us in the hallway.”

She threw her arms around my neck and pulled me close. “Are you sure you’re not going to get mad if...”

“If?”

We kissed and she invaded my mouth with her tongue. She was suddenly more passionate with me than ever. “He just makes me feel so...” “ she stomped her foot and growled for lack of words.

“So what?”

She grimaced and jutted her jaw and drove her hand through her hair and checked herself in the mirror, dabbing the corner of her mouth with her pinky. “Feminine? If that makes any sense? I don’t know.”

“But you don’t with me?”

“See, that’s what I was afraid of, that you’d take it like that,” she said and she kissed me again. “But it’s not like that. He’s just... He’s a different kind of man, it doesn’t say anything about you, or about us. He just affects me that way.”

“We should get going.”

She tugged on my hand but didn’t lift herself from the counter edge yet. “Promise me you won’t get mad if we do.”

“Do what?”

“That’s just it, I don’t know, but I’m trying to tell you something!”

“What is it Noelle?” I opened the bathroom door.

“What if he wants to... ? Me?”

I looked at her. “Let’s go see his gaming room, he said it’s downstairs.”

I took her hand and she came this time. “It’s not going to be my fault, okay?”

I chuckled. “Let’s just go and see.”

I took her out of the bedroom and into the hallway. Chase was at the top of the stairs now talking with three other people with his hands relaxed in his pockets. He turned to see us and continued to finish what he was saying to the other people.

We came up behind him and Noelle dropped my hand and slid her arm around his waist and came up on her toes to kiss his neck. “We’re all set,” she said privately to him, and he looked over his shoulder at me as though checking with me. He nodded and I shrugged.

Noelle put her other hand flat on his stomach, her hand around his waist slipping inside the waist of his jeans. “So show us this gaming room now?” she said with her big serious eyes directly on his.

He paused a moment but then half grinned and said, "Right this way, madam."

Going back down the stairs took us back through the crowds at the party. I tagged along behind them not knowing the way, of course, while Chase, with one hand in his pocket and the other on Noelle's back, or around her neck, or playing in her hair, stepped from one group of people to another with brief friendly conversations checking in with people the way a good host does.

Between these stops, he leaned over, said whispers into Noelle's ear, made her smile or laugh, and he kissed her, or rather she kissed him, whenever and wherever she could. Her enthusiasm was infectious. She was eager. I saw her hand squeeze his ass, saw her tease him when no one was looking with her hand sliding down over the front of his pants. I couldn't believe what she turned into.

Chase, for his part, was not innocent. He tugged her hair too hard, something I'd never known about with Noelle. She didn't push him away, it only made her push her body into his and lash his face and neck with her tongue and generally do things in front of other people, if not just me, that I could never imagine she was capable of doing.

It took forever to make our way though the party, made doubly long because of the way they stopped and necked all the time. I looked away mostly.

What was I going to do, watch?

We got to a door and Chase turned around to find me somewhere behind them catching up. Noelle was hanging onto him with her fingers in the belt loop of his jeans, her other hand pushing through his hair as though styling it on the run for him, and kissing him, pushing her pelvis against his hip.

"You're sure you want to go down and see the gaming room?" he said.

I laughed thinking he was teasing. "No, I'd hate that!" I said and laughed more.

"Nobody will disturb us down there," he said privately to Noelle. She was hardly hearing him anymore though. She was pressing her pelvis in circles against him and tugging at his hair and licking his neck and groaning with impatience at him.

"It's the most private room in the house," he said over his shoulder to me. "For obvious reasons."

"Obviously," I said, my excitement growing.

He continued to pause at the top of the stairs. "So yeah, let's go see it then," I said finally.

He went down with Noelle hanging on his arm and I followed.

"Shut the door, will you?" he said over his shoulder to me.

We came down into a blank marble tiled hallway. He gestured for us to continue to the end. There he entered a code into a keypad. It buzzed and clicked and he squeezed the handle but stopped.

"You can change your mind," he said.

I just laughed. But Noelle, she was virtually grinding herself against him, she was nearly moaning out loud, she was driving her hand through his hair and nearly pushing her whole hand down the front of his pants. She kissed his mouth frantically. "Come on!" she groaned in his ear through her teeth. I'd never seen her like that before. It frankly kind of scared me, her transformation.

He opened the door and automatically black light neon strips came on. I was nearly knocked over by the effect. It looked like the bridge of a starship coming to life. I looked over my shoulder at him and dropped my jaw wide open.

"Go on, try it out, fully hydraulic gaming rig."

"Holy fuck," I said, nearly breathless. I looked at Noelle but she didn't give it more than a cursory look before returning to his mouth, his chest, his pants. She was tugging his shirt up.

"Why not you get relaxed over there a minute," he said softly to her, and he gestured her over to a long couch against one side.

She parted from him and disappeared into the darker side of the small room.

Chase put his hand on my upper back and guided me to the big captain's chair. "What game you like? You like racing games? You look like a racer to me," he said.

I sat down in the seat and rubbed my hands down the leather sides.

"How about Assetto Corsa Competizione? You now that one?"

"The best there is," I said.

"You got that right." He pulled it up for me, started the set up. "Me and your girlfriend, we're just going to be over here in the spectator area," he said, and he chuckled.

I looked over my shoulder. Behind me about six feet back Noelle waved from the couch. Chase came down carefully beside her.

“Eyes on the prize now,” he said to me and he gestured to the triple screen dropping down in front of me.

The game was loaded and ready. The track was slick. The sky was dark. Headlights were on. I chose seat front view. When I revved the engine, the speaker in the wings of my chair nearly hurt my ears and the whole seat torqued and vibrated hard with the engine coming to life.

I spun around amazed and looked for Noelle. But she was already necking with Chase, turned sideways to him, her leg flowing up over his thigh, his hands driving through her hair.

“Noelle,” I said. She broke the kiss with Chase and looked up at me. “One day I will have this,” I said and I laughed mad scientist like.

“Better get racing baby,” she said nearly breathlessly and she gestured to the screens in front of me. My seat, the whole set up, in fact, leaned back on its hydraulics and it suddenly felt like I was accelerating at over 1G already.

I was at the first corner in a flash and I turned the wheel too hard, crashed out and spun. The seat threw me sideways. I caught a glimpse over my shoulder of Noelle settling down in Chase’s lap straddling him.

But I had no time to think about that. I respawned and learned to control things better with the game restarting automatically and I made it through the first turn this time without crashing, only to fly too hard to brake quick enough for the hairpin, and the hydraulics threw me up and sent me down simulating a violent crash, and I laughed at how incredibly realistic it all felt and sounded. I was exhilarated and laughing at the sensation of it all. The motion rig was like nothing I’d ever experienced.

It turned me right around as my car flew over the edge of the track on my next try, and I saw in a rapidly passing glimpse before I died again Noelle rising on her knees higher over Chase who was now deeper slumped in the couch. Her arms were straight up and he was lifting her dress up off her body.

But the rig spun me back into starting position and my car was respawned around me. I revved the engine and laughed again at the sensation of the sound all around me, and how it torqued with my revs.

This time I focused hard on the gears, felt out the clutch better, practiced my foot going back and forth from the brakes to the gas, and narrowed my eyes at the track all around me.

The lights flashed green and I took off under far more control this time, having got used to the wild sensations that were all so realistic. The rig

tipped left and right, up and down, and it spun and twisted. I felt the G-forces in my chest and head. I got spun around again but managed to hold on. But to the side of the screen for a passing moment, I saw Noelle kneeling high over Chase, this time with her arms behind her back unclasping her bra.

When the rig spun hard the other way, I saw a glimpse of her again shaking her arms to let the shoulder straps of her bra fall down to her hands.

But the game wasn't letting me stay still for long, the spectator stands flashing by in a blur, the roar of the crowd pumping my heart even higher, and in my mirrors, other cars jostled to darting left, darting right, trying to pass me.

I hit a long sweeping curve and barely held on to the steering wheel, I was thrown so hard into the frame on my right. I was disoriented, so deep into the simulation had I gone, that I didn't realize I was in reality tipped by the rig almost fully onto my right side, and that I wasn't in fact flying around a long hard curve.

Under my feet was where I saw Noelle this time. Or rather, Chase, kneeling on the floor, his back to me. I was already spun away and whipped over the other side before I could make out what was going on behind me. When my car turned hard through the opposite curve, I saw Chase ease my girlfriend's bare legs over his shoulders, and his head ducked down between her thighs. All this I saw in one millisecond.

I was getting good already at this game, and I wasn't crashing so much anymore. It wasn't giving me a break, though. I couldn't call over to Noelle, I couldn't even watch what was going on the couch for longer than a flash at a time. But I saw her naked body, and Chase's too, all over the couch together.

There were cars with angry whining engines coming up beside me and dropping back away. There were spectator stands down every straight, crowds roaring. You could even hear high female voices screaming, it was so exciting.

I was flat on my back accelerating down a straight, heading straight for a wall but I was determined to get past the car that was blocking me, and I knew he'd have to break hard, and that I had to get past him before I hit my brakes. When I did, my motion rig seemed to point me straight toward the floor, the anti-g-force was so great. My tires screeched and I could hear spectators screaming.

But I came at the wall too hard and crashed through it. I squeezed the pause button on the steering wheel, needing to catch my breath. I needed to reset my nerves. I was breathing hard, my heart rate was through the roof, my palms were sweaty.

At first, I was confused, not knowing why there'd still be screaming in the spectator stands. I twisted around to see if Chase was watching, to see if he was hearing the spectators like I was.

But his head was deep down between Noelle's legs, her fingers were pushing and tugging in the hair on the back of his head, and her heels were scraping down his back.

Her dress was over the arm of the couch, her white lace bra was hung over the back. I saw her panties, rolled up and scrunched like they had been whipped off in a hurry, lying on the floor.

The cries I heard were not the spectators at the race. When my speakers drew quiet as the game reset, I realized they were Noelle, high-pitched, breathy, and frantic. Her whole body was contorting and writhing under his mouth.

The engines roared back to life. The pause button only gives you three seconds. If I didn't get my head back in the race, I was going to get dumped at the side of the track again. I was going to get relegated to a lower level.

I gripped the wheel, pumped the gas, and squinted at the track. It was sunset in the simulation. The sky was lit gold and red. There were screens to the left and right of me showing other drivers also hunching up and ready for take off.

The immersion was complete, the simulation was all embracing. I was in the middle of the starting pack and I could feel the rumble of all the surrounding engines deep in my guts. We all took off together and they made minor and aggressive bumps on my fenders and bumpers that made me laugh with maniacal thrill, you could so feel every little thing.

I was nowhere near the higher levels of this game. Chase seemed to know where I belonged without even asking me, and he had me nailed exactly right. I was at a level he knew I could win at, but also where I was just as likely to lose. But I saw the level the game was last on at, his level. It wasn't even something I was prepared to contemplate.

My group of tightly packed cars bumped and roared together around the high curve and I bided my time determined to finish the race and avoid relegation to a lower level. Hard to the right we flew, then hard to the left.

The rig leaned far back when I pressed the gas to the floor, and it flew forward and down when I touched the brakes and stuck with my pack past the wall of death that got me twice already.

I heard that distinct cry again and instinctively I spun in my chair to glance around the wing with the speaker. I could only look for a millisecond, the race gave you no mercy. My mind was distracted though. I couldn't tell what I saw and waited until I was hitting another curve the other way so that I could manage a quick glance over my other shoulder.

I hit the pause and held it, which flashed up the indefinite pause on the screen. There were controls I discovered on the sides of the seat that moved it through all the hydraulics even without the screen barreling you through turns and accelerations.

There was a music track in the speakers in the room I realized were not part of the game, that Chase must have put it on. It was a low droning hip hop tune. I touched the screen button and all three lifted like a sunroof up and out of the way overhead. I pressed the seat button and guided the rig slowly around until I was facing the couch.

The music covered up the fact that the rig and the game wasn't making sound anymore. I tilted my head sideways and finally made out what I was seeing on the couch. My girlfriend was on her knees and elbows sideways to me, and under her, the other way around, on his back was Chase. His hands were wrapped around her hips. Her hand was wrapped around what her mouth couldn't get all the way in. They were both pumping on each other.

I hit the button and brought the rig back around to starting position facing the other way. I closed my eyes but could hear under the music Noelle's gasps, her muffled moans, and then the crack of Chase slapping her ass. I heard my girlfriend laugh with high pitched delight.

I lowered the screens back into position and gripped the steering wheel and slumped forward in my seat. They were obviously unaware I had stopped frozen. I heard them shifting, heard Noelle laugh, heard her gasp sharply. Slowly, tentatively, like someone not wanting to see the accident they know they were going to look at, I leaned out of the seat as far as the driver's tether belts would let me and peered around the edge of the speaker wing beside my head.

I knew what I was going to see but I looked anyway. Chase was sitting up again, slumped deeply in the couch. Noelle was straddling him again, but this time with nothing on at all. I always loved looking at her bare back, which I had to sneak in with her, she was always so shy naked, dashing from bathroom to bedroom when she forgot her robe or needed a towel.

With one eye I saw her lift herself higher on her knees and reach around behind her back, her body twisting and bending. Below her she found his cock and wrapped her hand around it, stroked it, pulled on it, rubbed her palm over the head. She spread her fingers down the length of it and leaned her head down between her shoulders and her hair fell around his face. I felt vaguely ridiculous, playing a racing game while my girlfriend was mounting a man in the darkness behind me.

But then, why was I peeking around the side of the chair to watch? Her back twisted and contorted, her hair fell and swept over her face. She teased herself with him. I heard her laugh at his mounting impatience. She was having fun. It wasn't lost on me that she was just as aware of me in the room as I was of her. She would never do such a thing behind my back. She couldn't conceive of doing it, I knew her enough to know.

I saw the glint of slickness on him from her, a string of his pre-cum stretch from the tip to her fold where she touched them together, and I saw her fist curl where her hand braced her in the back of the couch, holding her up over him. Her whole body was shaking now like a plank held too long. They were murmuring. They were kissing. They were teasing. She kept holding him off and laughing. I had no idea where this playful, sexual, flirting version of Noelle was from.

But it was all only possible because I was letting it happen. Yes, I thought, curling my hand around wheel, my finger on the button ready to release the pause, my girlfriend was about to fuck my friend's older brother on the couch in his gaming room directly behind me. But like my finger on the pause button of his whole gaming set up rig, I still controlled it, didn't I.

I shook like she did. And then I heard her sharp inhalation, her high-pitched pained cry, and I pressed the button and re-entered the race at full speed flying down the back straight, massive powerful machines at top speed bumping my bumper and my sides, the roar of engines covering up all the other sounds behind me. I didn't have to see it to know she sank down on him all the way engulfing him.

I remained immersed in the game until I was startled by Noelle's hand tapping my shoulder, and I paused it and turned around. The lights in the room were up. Chase was gone. Noelle was dressed and holding her clutch. She even had her shoes back on.

"Hey," she said, and she pursed her mouth and widened her eyes at me. "What do you think? Should we maybe get going?"

I eased myself out of the restraints and left the game on pause. I had no idea how to properly shut it down. We went out the room and spotted a door to outside from the lower level, and came out onto a patio and found our way around the side of the house and out to the street in front.

We held hands and shuffled to my car saying nothing. All the way home we said nothing, though I knew I could have said something to ease her feelings. I knew she'd be feeling guilty or caught or shameful. I guess she was no doubt caught up in knowing I must have been feeling a whole range of things, too, having sat there playing games while she... while she did what she did.

There was some kind of tacit agreement, it seemed. We didn't mention it the next day or the following week, and by the passage of a few weeks, the whole thing had receded into some black box under the stairs.

If anything, we were closer and more affectionate and attentive to each other than anytime before. We knew secrets about each other now, I theorized. It was like the way a couple can grow closer and more caring after they bare their souls and reveal their deepest darkest secrets to each other, only for us, we might have done so in action more than talk.

About four weeks after the party, Noelle came to me where I was gaming on the couch. I paused and looked up. I could tell she had something to say.

"So, Chase? The guy whose house..." she said, as though I'd forget the name.

"Yeah, yeah?"

She wiggled her phone at me to tell me he sent her a text. The fact they had each other's number struck me.

"Sooo," she started again and her mouth crept up with a guilty grin. "Yeah, so he's got two tickets to a show? He's wondering..."

"For us?" I popped my eyes wide open.

She grimaced and sat down beside me, patted my back, tapped my thigh. "For me," she said quietly. "Him and me?"

“He wants to take you to a show? What show?” I said, not quite registering what she was telling me.

“Cigarettes After Sex are at the Rio tonight,” she said and she shrugged.

I turned back to the screen with my game frozen on pause. “Oh. And I guess you want to go.”

“Only if you think so,” she quickly replied.

“But you want to go without me.”

“He’ll bring me back.”

I sighed. I started my game again and didn’t give her an answer. She remained beside me staring at the side of my expressionless face. I finally said toward the screen, “Well you better get ready then.”

She instantly kissed my cheek, told me she loved me, and dashed down the hall. I looked over and saw her dash into the bathroom naked.

She came out much later transformed, reaching up to hang large earrings from her lobes.

“What do you think?” she said, spreading her hands down the front of her dress.

“Is that new too?” I said.

She blushed instantly. “He wanted me to tell you but I didn’t know how.”

“Tell me what?”

“He bought this for me last week.”

I nodded piecing together yet more new information. Finally I said, “You look incredible,” because she did, her make up flawless, her lips full and glowing, her eyes big and clear and sparkling.

If she was a different Noelle that night at the party, tonight she wasn’t even Noelle at all. It was hard to see her as the same person, she was so transformed.

But I didn’t have long to wonder about that before her phone buzzed and she leapt to it and said “He’s here!”

I saw her off at the door, her increasingly impatient with my questions. The last thing she said was, “I don’t know when he’s going to bring me back, maybe don’t stay up?”

I watched her rush down the hallway to the elevator, stand and wait for it, giving me a very nice side profile of her exquisite form, before the door opened and she stepped forward turning to wave at me goodbye. She knew I was staring at her profile the whole time.

“Good night!” she called in a hushed voice to respect the neighbors, and she blew me a kiss and the doors closed on her.

Would it be wrong to admit that I was grinning with pride at the thought?